

# Converting the garage's second story to an ADU — what the county asks for

17054 Handlebar Rd · APN 278-361-08-00 · compiled 9/16/2026 from the county's own documents, all saved in [reference/adu/](#). Owner's purpose: take the 822 SF rec room out of the ZO §6156.g accessory-structure count (4,000 SF cap) by making it a dwelling unit. Result: barn 2,200 + garage ground floor 934 + coop 60 = **3,194 SF**.

## 1. Zoning — why this works (PDS-611, rev 9/2/2026)

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- The rec room is **existing and permitted** (PDS2008-1006-20080403: "934 SQFT DETACHED GARAGE W/ 822 SQFT 2ND-STORY REC ROOM W/ AC"). That is the whole key.
- PDS-611: *"No additional development standards such as maximum square footage, height, lot coverage, and setbacks (except for fire safety) are required if an existing and permitted detached or attached accessory structure is being converted into an ADU."* And: *"Such a conversion would not be subject to any size requirements."* So the 1,200 SF cap does not apply; 822 SF is fine.
- Up to **150 SF may be added solely for ingress/egress** (a stair or landing). Anything more is treated as new construction and gets the new-construction caps.
- The ADU sits over the garage, so PDS-611 requires *"a defined fire and sound separation wall or floor between the ADU and"* the garage, with rated openings.
- **Floor-area math goes on the plans, measured from the interior of the outside walls**, for both the house and the ADU.
- Parking: no replacement parking is owed when a garage is converted. One ADU space may be required; it can be tandem in the existing driveway.
- **The ADU may not be rented for less than 30 days**. It cannot be a Farmhouse Getaways short-term unit. Long-term rental or family use only.
- No owner-occupancy requirement for an ADU (there is one for a JADU).
- Fire sprinklers: not required in the ADU if the main house was never required to have them (ADU Handbook).

## 2. Septic first — DEHQ (ADU FAQ, rev 2/1/2021)

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DEHQ says, in its own words, *"Should I wait to submit a Building Permit Application until after I obtain DEHQ approval? Yes."* PDS will reject a site plan without well and septic locations, and the septic answer can change the cost.

1. Hire an **OWTS professional** (DEHQ keeps a list at [sandiegocounty.gov/deh/septic](http://sandiegocounty.gov/deh/septic)). They prepare and submit the **OWTS Layout Application** showing the house and the ADU both served by a system that meets current standards, with a 100% reserve area.
2. Expect **percolation testing** in the proposed disposal and reserve areas; DEHQ only accepts old data in narrow cases.
3. Tank sizing table: a **4-bedroom house + 1-bedroom ADU needs a 1,500-gallon tank minimum**. DEHQ notes an ADU "in almost every case" exceeds the existing tank and field, so plan on a second tank and/or an expanded disposal area. The existing tank and leach lines sit just north and east of the garage — short runs.

4. Pull the **as-built of the existing septic** from the DEHQ document library ([sandiegocounty.gov/content/sdc/deh/doclibrary](http://sandiegocounty.gov/content/sdc/deh/doclibrary)) before the professional visits.
5. DEHQ layout approval expires after **1 year** — sequence it right before the building submittal.
6. Correspondence: [lwqduty.deh@sdcounty.ca.gov](mailto:lwqduty.deh@sdcounty.ca.gov).

### 3. Fire district

PDS-611 and the handbook both say to contact the fire district early (Ramona Municipal Water District Fire / CAL FIRE). The parcel is in a wildfire zone, so expect WUI construction requirements (PDS 664: ignition-resistant exterior, vents, Class A roof) on any altered exterior, and fuel-modification shown on the plot plan.

### 4. The building-permit plan set (PDS 658 + PDS 441A)

Two identical sets; 11"×17" is acceptable for a minor project; everything dimensioned and drawn to scale; new vs existing clearly marked.

| Sheet                    | Must show                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Title / SP-1             | Address, owner, sheet index, project data: use, <b>floor area of each use (interior dims)</b> , occupancy (R-3 over U garage), construction type, code editions                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Plot plan                | PDS 090 plot plan — the rev 3x sheet already carries almost all of it. Add: ADU label on the garage, well and <b>septic locations with the DEHQ layout</b> , ADU parking space, fuel-modification zone, utilities                                                                                                                                                |
| Floor plan               | Both levels. Room sizes and uses, ceiling heights, all doors/windows with sizes and operation, <b>kitchen</b> (sink, cooking, counter, storage) and <b>full bathroom with shower or tub</b> , water heater, HVAC, smoke and CO alarms, <b>egress window in every sleeping room</b> , <b>fire separation to the garage below</b> (wall, ceiling, door protection) |
| Elevations               | Every side; openings, roof, finishes, grades, eave projections; the new stair/landing if added                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Cross sections + framing | Existing structure with the floor/ceiling assembly upgraded for the rated separation; stair details, guards and handrails                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Energy                   | Title-24 calcs (CF1R) by a third party; HERS items listed; insulation matching                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Electrical               | For ≤400 A service no separate plan — show lighting, GFCI, alarms, fans on the floor plan                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Stormwater               | Intake form + Standard SWQMP; for a conversion the added impervious area is ~0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| WUI                      | PDS 664 fire-resistive items on any exterior work                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |

Other submittal items: permit application, **Owner-Builder form PDS 421** if you pull it yourself, evidence of legal parcel (PM 5062, already in hand), assessor set at issuance. Unlicensed owners may draw conventional wood-frame plans (PDS 118); anything non-conventional needs a licensed designer.

### 5. Sequence and time

1. Septic layout with an OWTS professional → DEHQ approval (weeks to a few months; this is the gate).
2. Fire district pre-check.

3. Plan set → PDS Building submittal, plan-check fees due at submittal.
4. Plan check: ~4-week first cycle for residential; about half of projects need more than two cycles. Clean plans are the only lever.
5. Impact/agency fees at issuance (TIF, park, school, fire mitigation). State law waives impact fees for ADUs **under 750 SF**; at 822 SF, fees are charged in proportion to the primary dwelling.
6. Build, inspect, final. Only then is the rec room out of the \$6156.g count.

## 6. What it means for the store plot plan

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Until the ADU permit is issued, PDS's count is 4,016 SF (garage 1,756 + barn 2,200 + coop 60). File the ADU application before or alongside the store plot plan, and label the garage's upper floor on the plot plan "ADU — PERMIT PDS2026-..." with the accessory subtotal at 3,194 SF.

## Sources (all in [reference/adu/](#))

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PDS-611 ADU & JADU (Zoning, rev 9/2/2026) · PDS 607 / 607A Standard ADU checklist and guidance · PDS 658 Minimum essential plan submittal items · PDS 441A Building permit submittal steps · DEHQ ADU/OWTS FAQ (2/1/2021) · County ADU Handbook.